

Skin Manifestations and Classification of Lupus Erythematosus

Lupus Erythematosus-Specific Skin Lesions (Cutaneous Lupus Erythematosus, CLE)

- **Discoid lupus erythematosus (DLE)** causes scarring and can lead to permanent disfigurement.
- **Subacute cutaneous lupus erythematosus (SCLE)** and **acute cutaneous lupus erythematosus (ACLE)** are highly photosensitive and typically **non-scarring**.

Lupus Erythematosus-Non-Specific Skin Lesions

These include: - **Non-scarring alopecia** ("lupus hair", telogen effluvium) - **Oral ulcers** - **Photosensitivity** - **Raynaud phenomenon** - **Cutaneous vasculitis/vasculopathy** (e.g., livedo reticularis, palpable purpura, thrombophlebitis, erythromelalgia) - **Sclerodactyly**

These non-specific lesions often precede or herald a flare of **systemic lupus erythematosus (SLE)**.

Pathogenesis of Systemic Lupus Erythematosus (SLE)

SLE is a disorder characterized by an interplay between **host factors** (e.g., genetic susceptibility, hormonal environment) and **environmental triggers** such as: - **Ultraviolet (UV) radiation** - **Viral infections** - **Certain drugs**

This interaction leads to: - **Loss of self-tolerance** - **Induction of autoimmunity** - **Activation and expansion of the immune system** - **Subsequent immunologic tissue injury**

Treatment of Lupus Erythematosus

Therapeutic approaches include: - **Sun protection** (broad-spectrum sunscreens) - **Topical and short-term systemic glucocorticoids** - **Antimalarials** (e.g., hydroxychloroquine – first-line for cutaneous and systemic disease) - **Retinoids** - **Immunosuppressive agents** (e.g., methotrexate, azathioprine, mycophenolate mofetil) - **Thalidomide** (for refractory cutaneous disease) - **Biologic therapies** (e.g., belimumab)

Epidemiology

Lupus erythematosus occurs significantly more often in women than in men, with a **female-to-male ratio of approximately 9:1**.

Gilliam Classification of Skin Lesions in Lupus Erythematosus

Table: The Gilliam Classification of Skin Lesions Associated with Lupus Erythematosus

I. LE-Specific Skin Disease (Cutaneous LE, CLE)	II. LE–Non-Specific Skin Disease
A. Acute Cutaneous LE (ACLE)	A. Cutaneous Vascular Disease
1. Localized ACLE (malar/butterfly rash)	1. Vasculitis
2. Generalized ACLE (maculopapular rash, photosensitive dermatitis)	a. Leukocytoclastic vasculitis
	(1) Palpable purpura
	(2) Urticarial vasculitis
	b. Polyarteritis nodosa–like lesions
B. Subacute Cutaneous LE (SCLE)	2. Vasculopathy
1. Annular SCLE (lupus marginatus, etc.)	a. Degos disease–like lesions
2. Papulosquamous SCLE (psoriasiform, pityriasiform, etc.)	b. Secondary atrophie blanche (livedoid vasculitis)
	3. Periungual telangiectasia
	4. Livedo reticularis
	5. Thrombophlebitis
	6. Raynaud phenomenon
	7. Erythromelalgia
C. Chronic Cutaneous LE (CCLE)	B. Non-Scarring Alopecia
1. Classic discoid LE (DLE)	1. “Lupus hair”
a. Localized DLE	2. Telogen effluvium
b. Generalized DLE	3. Alopecia areata
2. Hypertrophic/verrucous DLE	C. Sclerodactyly
3. Lupus profundus (lupus panniculitis)	